

BENJAMIN ENKE

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EMPLOYMENT

2026– **Visiting Instructor, Department of Economics, Massachusetts Institute of Technology**

2020–2026 **Associate and then Paul Sack Associate Professor of Economics, Harvard University**

2016–2020 **Assistant Professor of Economics, Harvard University**

EDUCATION

2016 **Ph.D. in Economics (*summa cum laude*), University of Bonn**

2010 **Diploma in Law and Economics, University of Augsburg**

WORKING PAPERS

Reference Points as Information (with M. Dean, T. Graeber and P. Ortoleva)

Comparisons (with T. Graeber)

Market Prices as a Moral Currency

A Note on “When Are Decisions Improvable? An Evaluation of Diagnostic Methods” (with T. Graeber)

Quantifying Lottery Choice Complexity (with C. Shubatt)
Revise & resubmit, Econometrica

REVIEWS AND PERSPECTIVES

Moral Boundaries

Annual Review of Economics, 2024, vol. 16 (1), pp. 133-157

‘Morality and Political Economy’ from the Vantage Point of Economics

PNAS Nexus, 2024, vol. 3 (10), 309.

Handbook of Culture and Economic Behavior (co-editor with Paola Giuliano, Nathan Nunn and Leonard Wantchekon)

To appear in Elsevier Handbooks in Economics

PUBLICATIONS AND ACCEPTED PAPERS

Behavioral Attenuation (with T. Graeber, R. Oprea and J. Yang)
Forthcoming, Journal of Political Economy

Herding, Armed Conflict and a Culture of Honor (with Y. Cao, A. Falk, P. Giuliano and N. Nunn)
Conditionally accepted, American Economic Review

Capturing the Complexity of Human Strategic Decision-Making with Machine Learning (with J.-Q. Zhu, J. Peterson and T. Griffiths)
Nature Human Behaviour, 2025, vol. 9 (10), pp. 2114-2120

Complexity and Time (with T. Graeber and R. Oprea)
Journal of the European Economic Association, 2025, vol. 23 (5), pp. 1838-1867.

Values as Luxury Goods and Political Behavior (with M. Polborn and A. Wu)
Journal of the European Economic Association, 2025, vol. 23 (5), pp. 1635-1668

Universalism: Global Evidence (with A. Cappelen and B. Tungodden)
American Economic Review, 2025, vol. 115 (1), pp. 43-76

Trust in Scientists and their Role in Society Across 68 Countries (with a many-labs team led by Viktoria Cologna and Niels Mede)
Nature Human Behaviour, 2025, vol. 9 (1), pp. 713-720.

Universalism and Political Representation: Evidence from the Field (with R. Fisman, L. Mota Freitas and S. Sun)
American Economic Review: Insights, 2024, vol. 6 (2), pp. 214-229.

Associative Memory, Beliefs and Market Interactions (with F. Schwerter and F. Zimmermann)
Journal of Financial Economics, 2024, vol. 157, 103853.

Cognitive Uncertainty (with T. Graeber)
Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2023, vol. 138 (4), pp. 2021-2067 (Lead Article).

Moral Universalism and the Structure of Ideology (with R. Rodríguez-Padilla and F. Zimmermann)
Review of Economic Studies, 2023, vol. 90 (4), 1934-1962.

Cognitive Biases: Mistakes or Missing Stakes? (with U. Gneezy, B. Hall, D. Martin, V. Nelidov, T. Offerman, and J. van de Ven)
Review of Economics and Statistics, 2023, vol. 105 (4), pp. 818-832.

Confidence, Self-Selection and Bias in the Aggregate (with T. Graeber and R. Oprea)
American Economic Review, 2023, vol. 113 (7), pp. 1933-1966.

Market Exposure and Human Morality
Nature Human Behaviour, 2023, vol. 7 (1), pp. 134-141.

Patience and Comparative Development (with T. Dohmen, A. Falk, D. Huffman, and U. Sunde)
Review of Economic Studies, 2022, vol. 89(10), pp. 2806-2840.

Moral Universalism: Measurement and Economic Relevance (with R. Rodríguez-Padilla and F. Zimmermann)
Management Science, 2022, vol. 68(5), pp. 3590-3603.

Confidence and Central Tendency in Perceptual Judgment (with Y. Xiang, T. Graeber, and S. Gershman)
Attention, Perception & Psychophysics, 2021, vol. 83, pp. 3024-3034.

Moral Values and Voting
Journal of Political Economy, 2020, vol. 128(10), pp. 3679-3729 (Lead Article).

What You See Is All There Is

Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2020, vol. 135(3), pp. 1363-1398.

Ancient Origins of the Global Variation in Economic Preferences (with A. Becker and A. Falk)

AEA Papers & Proceedings, 2020, vol. 110, pp. 319–323

Kinship, Cooperation, and the Evolution of Moral Systems

Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2019, vol. 134(2), pp. 953-1019.

Correlation Neglect in Belief Formation (with F. Zimmermann)

Review of Economic Studies, 2019, vol. 86(1), pp. 313-332.

Global Evidence on Economic Preferences (with A. Falk, A. Becker, T. Dohmen, D. Huffman, and U. Sunde)

Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2018, vol. 133(4), pp. 1645-1692 (*Lead Article*).

The Precision of Subjective Data and the Explanatory Power of Economic Models (with T. Drerup and H.-M. von Gaudecker)

Journal of Econometrics, 2017, vol. 200(2), pp. 378-389

TEACHING

GRADUATE

2026–2027 Experimental Economics, Topics in Behavioral Economics, Massachusetts Institute of Technology

2017–2024 Experimental Economics, Harvard University

2016-2018, 2024-2025 Reading group in Behavioral Economics, Harvard University

UNDERGRADUATE

2026 Psychology and Economics, Massachusetts Institute of Technology

2017–2023 Economics and Morality, Harvard University

AWARDS AND HONORS

2025 Zeuthen Lectures, University of Copenhagen

2025 Keynote, CESifo Conference on Behavioral Economics

2023 Most productive German economist in last five years, Wirtschaftswoche Magazine

2023 Keynote, MIT Sloan Workshop on Directions of Polarization

2021 Alfred P. Sloan Research Fellowship

2020 Capital Magazine “Germany’s Top 40 Under 40”

2019, 2020, 2022 Excellence in Refereeing Award, Review of Economic Studies

2018 Excellence in Refereeing Award, American Economic Review

- 2017 Distinguished CESifo Affiliate Award, Munich
- 2015 Runner-Up for Hillel Einhorn Award of the Society for Judgment and Decision Making
- 2006–2010 Friedrich Ebert Foundation Scholarship

PRESENTATIONS

- 2026 Chicago Booth, Berkeley, MIT Sloan, Boston University, Behavioral Economics Annual Meeting, Zurich Cognitive Economics Workshop, NBER Behavioral Finance, Yale Summer School in Behavioral Finance
- 2025 Brown Bravo Conference, CESifo Conference on Behavioral Economics, Berkeley, MIT, Boston College, UPenn Wharton, Brown, Bonn
- 2024 UCSD Spring School in Behavioral Economics, Behavioral Economics Annual Meeting, Yale Summer School in Behavioral Finance, Chicago Booth
- 2023 BFI OIG Conference, NBER POL Summer Institute, LSE Behavioral POL Conference, Columbia Workshop on Cognitive Noise, Copenhagen, Dartmouth, Pittsburgh, Princeton
- 2022 UCSD Spring School in Behavioral Economics, Sloan-NOMIS Summer School on Cognitive Foundations of Economic Behavior, Berkeley-UBC Political Economy conference, CESifo Behavioral Economics conference, Northwestern Kellogg, UCLA Anderson, Hamburg, Williams, Vanderbilt, Yale, IMT Lucca, Tilburg, Hong Kong University
- 2021 Bocconi, Columbia, Yale SOM, USC, Notre Dame, Alicante, Toronto, Berlin, Stanford, Berkeley, Middlebury, briq Workshop on Beliefs, Munich CESifo conference, Stanford PoliSci, Stony Brook PoliSci
- 2020 Virtual Behavioral Economics Seminar, Warwick Behavioral Science, Warwick Econ, UPenn Psychology, Michigan, IMF, Cambridge, NHH Bergen, UCSB, Düsseldorf
- 2019 Zurich, Harvard Cognitive Psychology, Harvard Government, Bergen, ERINN Conference London, East Coast Behavioral and Experimental Workshop, Bonn briq Workshop on Beliefs, Pompeu Fabra Conference on Political Economy of Development and Conflict
- 2018 MIT, Berkeley, Berkeley Haas, Stanford, CMU, UBC, UCLA Anderson, Boston University, MPI Bonn, Harvard, Boston University, NBER Economics of Culture & Institutions Meeting, NBER Organizational Economics Meeting, NBER Political Economy Summer Institute, Early-Career Behavioral Economics Conference, Behavioral Economics Annual Meeting, Brown Deep Rooted Factors of Comparative Development Conference, Warwick Summer School on Culture and Development
- 2017 Microsoft Research, UPenn Wharton, Harvard, Bonn, UCL, Behavioral Economics Annual Meeting, Stanford SITE, CESifo Munich
- 2016 Brown, Cornell, Harvard, HBS, Munich, Northwestern Kellogg, Princeton, UCLA Anderson, UCSD, Early-Career Behavioral Economics Conference
- Earlier Cologne, Essex, European Winter Meeting of the Econometric Society; NBER Political Economy Meeting; NYU Bounded Rationality in Choice Conference; NBER Economics of Culture & Institutions Meeting; Stanford SITE; Bay Area Behavioral and Experimental Economics Workshop

OTHER AFFILIATIONS AND ACTIVITIES

2018–2023 Associate Editor, *Journal of the European Economic Association*

2017– Faculty Research Fellow, National Bureau for Economic Research (NBER)

2017– Affiliate Member, CESifo Research Network, Germany

REFeree SERVICE

American Economic Review, Quarterly Journal of Economics, Econometrica, Review of Economic Studies, Journal of Political Economy, Journal of the European Economic Association, American Economic Review: Insights, AEJ: Micro, AEJ: Policy, Quantitative Economics, Review of Economics and Statistics, Journal of Development Economics, Journal of Public Economics, Journal of Economic Theory, Journal of Economic Growth, Management Science, Games and Economic Behavior, Review of Financial Studies, European Economic Review, Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization, Journal of Economics and Management Strategy, Science, Proceedings of the National Academy of Arts and Sciences, Psychological Review, American Political Science Review, National Science Foundation, European Research Council

COMMITTEE WORK

Graduate admissions; graduate recruiting; first-year graduate advising (all at Harvard)

ADVISING

(Former) students in academia: Bnaya Dreyfuss (University of Pittsburgh), Yihong Huang (Peking University), Aakaash Rao (Northwestern Kellogg), Raphael Raux (MIT Sloan), Cassidy Shubatt (on market in 2026-27), Mattie Toma (Warwick Business School), Jeffrey Yang (UCSB)

Last update: September 26, 2026